

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Establish Energization Timelines.

Rulemaking 24-01-018
(Filed January 25, 2024)

**COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON THE
PROPOSED DECISION ESTABLISHING TARGET ENERGIZATION TIME PERIODS
AND PROCEDURE FOR CUSTOMERS TO REPORT ENERGIZATION DELAYS**

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Date: August 29, 2024

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In accordance with the Rules of Practice and Procedure of the California Public Utilities Commission (“Commission”), the Vehicle-Grid Integration Council (“VGIC”) hereby submits these comments on the *Decision Establishing Target Energization Time Periods and Procedure for Customers to Report Energization Delays* (“Proposed Decision” or “PD”) issued by President Alice Reynolds on August 12, 2024.

I. INTRODUCTION.

VGIC supports the PD’s establishment of energization timelines for the investor-owned utilities (“IOUs”). This is an important first step to improving customer experience and satisfaction with the energization process. VGIC strongly supports the Commission requiring IOUs to provide a wide range of data and information on energization, as outlined in Appendix B to the PD. As the PD discusses, “The data collected [...] can improve the Commission’s ability to identify the appropriate amount of future acceleration of the large electric IOUs’ energization target(s) in Phase 2 of this proceeding.”¹ The PD correctly explains that the timeline targets laid out in the PD will

¹ PD at 70.

most likely require refinement since, even under the proposed requirements, timelines will remain long and exceed customer expectations.

In this proceeding, VGIC has discussed using flexible service connection approaches as important bridge solutions to energize sites that would otherwise face lengthy energization timelines. This can be done by energizing only a portion of load, changing import limits according to a pre-set schedule, responding dynamically in response to signals from Advanced Distribution Management Systems (“ADMS”) or Distributed Energy Resource Management Systems (“DERMS”), or other potential pathways. Flexible service connections will be critical in enabling the IOUs to better meet energization timelines in the near and even mid-term, especially for projects requiring distribution or upstream system upgrades.

The PD does not discuss flexible service connections, but Appendix B of the PD does propose collecting limited data on them. Given that two IOUs are running flexible service connection pilots and that the Commission and many stakeholders are actively discussing how to expand these offerings, additional data should be gathered on the use of flexible service connections within IOU service territory. VGIC respectfully urges the Commission to revise the PD to incorporate additional data points in Appendix B supported by the record.

II. ADDITIONAL DATA SHOULD BE GATHERED ON FLEXIBLE SERVICE CONNECTIONS.

In Appendix B of the PD, Questions 32 and 34 ask whether a flexible service connection was used for a given project and “if flexible service was utilized to provide service, the amount of load (kW) provided to the applicant, the remaining load requested by the applicant, and an estimate for when full service will be provided to the applicant.”² VGIC strongly supports the inclusion of

² PD, Appendix B at 4.

these two questions, which will provide a basic – and currently lacking – understanding of how many customers are using flexible service connections.

However, the PD presents a critical opportunity to gather additional data to inform the development of different flexible service connection offerings. VGIC recommends adding the following additional data requests to Appendix B:

- The party proposing the flexible service connection - the utility or the customer.
- The type of the accepted flexible service connection (pre-programmed schedule, dynamic dispatch, etc.)
- The type of flexible service connection technology in use (e.g., power control systems, integrated or co-located generation or storage).

VGIC recommended these questions in its *Opening Comments on the Scoping Memo* of this proceeding. In those comments, VGIC explained that there is no standardized process for flexible service connections and no clear path to better understanding the types and scale of flexible service connections in use, the extent to which they can shorten energization timelines, or the deferred and/or avoided costs that result from leveraging flexible service connections.

Pacific Gas and Electric (“PG&E”) and Southern California Edison (“SCE”) are currently running separate flexible service connection pilots. Both IOUs will gather and share some data. For example, SCE will provide the Commission with biannual updates on its LCMS pilot. However, those reports will focus on the technical performance of LCMS equipment and accounting of rejected LCMS applications and the reasons for the rejections.³ VGIC supports the gathering of this information. However, in developing broader flexible service connection service offerings, the additional information requested above will help to guide the Commission towards

³ SCE Advice Letter 5138-E at 9.

making better-informed choices about how to move forward. Some flexible service options, for example, certain schedules may be more popular with customers, and the IOUs and customers may find technologies best suited to enabling flexible service connections. Also, while it seems that the IOUs are currently the entities that recommend the pilots to their customers, as customers and developers become more familiar with new options, they may ask the IOUs if flexible service connection options are available to them.

Given that these pilots are ongoing, the Commission should start to gather as much data as possible on customer use of flexible service connections and preferences for different options. This is especially important because the Commission should authorize expanded flexible service connection offerings before the scheduled end of the pilots. As the IOUs face challenging delays in energization timelines for many customers, especially large EV charging customers, the Commission should work to allow for more rapid processes as soon as possible. Already, the Commission had clawed back its adopted efforts on automated load management, initiated by the 2020 VGI Strategies and SB 676 Implementation Decision (D.20-12-029), such that two IOUs have initiated separate (much-needed) flexible service connection pilots. VGIC urges the Commission to avoid once again allowing the situation to evolve without its leadership to ensure that policy development is coherent, intentional, and data-backed.

III. CHANGES TO ENERGIZATION RULES TO ENABLE FLEXIBLE SERVICE CONNECTION SHOULD BE TAKEN UP IN A TIMELY MANNER.

VGIC has commented many times that flexible service connections are a cross-proceeding issue. The High DER Proceeding (R.21-06-017) is taking up many issues related to establishing the flexible service connection options, including the development of Limited Load Profiles, implementation of power control system standards, methods of allocating available Firm and Non-

Firm distribution system hosting capacity, and overall technical requirements and utility business practices needed to operationalize flexible service connection. Stakeholders have submitted comments on these issues and will continue to engage in the High DER proceeding to develop broader offerings.

At the same time, enabling broad flexible service connection may require changes to the IOUs energization rules. In response to a motion from Enphase Energy on flexible service connections in R.21-06-017, the Commission stated that “Any changes to the energization rules will be addressed in a proceeding specific to energization.”⁴ Therefore, VGIC recommends that modifications to the energization rules to allow for flexible service connections be explicitly scoped into in Phase 2 of this proceeding. If the Commission cannot scope this into Phase 2 at this time, the issue should be taken up in a timely manner in this proceeding as soon as conversations in the High DER proceeding turn towards energization rule modification. VGIC reiterates its above caution: the Commission should seize the present opportunity to expeditiously adopt the necessary elements of a flexible service connection framework,⁵ rather than waiting for the on-the-ground energization timeline situation to become dire enough to warrant further *ad hoc*, inconsistent, and ill-defined IOU-initiated programs. While energization timeline goals and targets are helpful guidance, we still lack the necessary tools to achieve these timelines and flexible service connection offers one of the few tools available to us.

IV. CONCLUSION.

⁴ Administrative Law Judges’ Ruling Denying Enphase Motion At 6.

⁵ These elements may include, for example, clear and consistent technology eligibility rules, effective channels for customers and utilities to initiate and navigate the flexible service connection process, optional flexible service connection types (e.g., Firm vs Non-Firm Import Limits, 288-value Limited Load Profiles, dynamic response to centralized ADMS/DERMS control, scaled service, etc.) customer enablement tools (e.g., hosting capacity maps that can support decisions regarding both *where* to install equipment and *how* to operate it), and a clear goals-outcomes-metrics framework to track the success of a given flexible service connection program, tariff, or other initiative.

VGIC appreciates the opportunity to provide these comments on the Proposed Decision. We look forward to further collaboration with the Commission and stakeholders on this initiative.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Zach Woogen

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Interim Executive Director

VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL

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